

Kalyan Singh, the chief minister of UP, was in Lucknow. We alighted from the dais and went in search of a telephone. We found one, but I could not contact Lucknow. It was there that I heard the first thud and was told by someone that one dome had fallen. I went rushing back to the roof-top of the Ram Katha Kunj. What I saw from there is etched in my mind. While the leaders on the dais were shocked at the unforeseen turn of events, the mood among the milling crowds below was quite the opposite. All of them seemed filled with a sense of relief and many among them were even elated. After sometime, another dome fell. The third dome met with the same fate soon thereafter. Someone came and started distributing sweets. I said, "No, I will not have sweets today".

Meanwhile, I got the message that I could speak with the chief minister in Lucknow. The essence of my conversation with him was that, in view of his government's failure to abide by the assurance he had given to the Supreme Court, he ought to tender his resignation. He agreed. I had made up my mind that I too would tender my resignation from the only official position that I occupied at that time. As soon as I reached Lucknow, I sent my letter of resignation by fax to the Speaker of the Lok Sabha.

I recall vividly an experience en route from Ayodhya to Lucknow. In spite of strict security all along the 135-kilometre journey, I could see people engaged in celebrations everywhere. Within half an hour of our departure from Ayodhya, our car was stopped by the police. On seeing that the car had Pramod Mahajan and me, a senior officer of the UP government walked up to us said, "*Advaniji, kuch bacha to nahin na? Bilkul saaf kar diya na?*" (I hope nothing of the structure is surviving and that it has been totally razed to the ground.) I am recounting this incident only to highlight the general mood of the populace, including employees and officials of the state government, after the tragic development in Ayodhya—was that of jubilation.

■ MANMOHAN SINGH

It was courageous of P.V. Narasimha Rao to try and effect a paradigm shift in the country's economic policy. Equally audacious was his decision to appoint Manmohan Singh, a widely respected economist but someone totally outside of the political system, as finance minister in his Cabinet. This decision made me feel that he meant business. As Prime Minister, he provided the much-needed political backing to Singh to embark on a bold agenda of economic reforms that slowly but steadily started demolishing the 'pseudo-socialist' edifice erected by the earlier Congress governments. I remember once, during a debate in Parliament, when Chandrashekhar had bitterly criticised the finance minister, even insinuating that he was an agent of the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund, I openly defended Singh. Some people in my own party questioned me over this, but I said that we should not counter the government on every issue just for the sake of opposing. In a recent television interview, I recalled this incident and said that, never before were the relations between the Government and the Opposition as constructive as during the initial phase of the Rao government. (*Times*



IN THE CASE OF EVERY OTHER
Prime Minister of India, the most important political address was invariably his residence. It is only during Singh's tenure that distinction has shifted to 10 Janpath.

Now TV, 18 September 2007).

My cordial relations with Manmohan Singh were established during those days. At a personal level, these relations are marked by warmth and mutual cordiality even now. However, my main grievance against Singh after he became Prime Minister is that he has allowed devaluation of his high office by surrendering to the authority of the Congress President. I said in the television interview that, in the case of every other Prime Minister of India, the most important political address in New Delhi was invariably the incumbent Prime Minister's residence. It is only during Singh's tenure that distinction has shifted to 10 Janpath.

In fact, even Rao had faced the difficult task of managing his relations with 10 Janpath which many in his Cabinet regarded as the only legitimate centre of power both in the Congress party and in a Congress government. But Rao, a shrewd politician, handled this task deftly, never ceding political authority to an extra-constitutional centre of power. Therefore, I began admiring him when, like Lal Bahadur Shastri, he too soon acquired Prime Ministerial stature on his own, without belonging to the Nehru-Gandhi dynasty.